The “Container” and its Containment: A Meeting Space for Psychoanalytic and Open Systems Theories

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Bion’s theoretical conceptualizations regarding processes in groups and in society, which he developed during the late 1940’s and 1950’s became a central factor in the pioneering work that developed at the Tavistock Institute after World War II regarding organizational theory and practice. This work attempted to make links and build bridges between psychoanalysis and systemic theories; between Melanie Klein’s psychoanalytic theories regarding the individual, Bion’s theories regarding group dynamic, and “open systems theory” of organizations (Miller and Rice, 1967).

One of the most prominent and influential thinkers and pioneers in these endeavors was Elliot Jaques (1955). His conceptualizations regarding anxiety, defenses and their connection to organizational structure and design became an anchor for those theorizing and working with organizations from a psychoanalytic perspective. However, some forty years later, Jaques presented a sharp turn in views. In his article: “Why the Psychoanalytical Approach to Understanding Organizations is Dysfunctional” (Jaques, 1995) he rejected his previously held views on the importance of the unconscious in understanding organizational dysfunctionality and on the use of psychoanalytically informed methods in organizational interventions. As an alternative to his own rejected views he offered an approach to organizational effectiveness and worker’s satisfaction that is based primarily on organizational structure and design. Jaques’ dramatic change of views, where psychoanalysis became “bad” and systemic concepts such as structure, design and authority, “good”, may perhaps be a manifestation of a conceptual splitting. Such splitting may partly be due to difficulties in conceptual integration between psychoanalytic and systemic thinking, and the way this integration is applied to

practice. Indeed, Armstrong (1995) raises questions regarding the meaning of organizational consultancy practice which is described as “psychoanalytic and systemic”. He writes: “What kind of coupling is envisaged here? Is it simply the coming together of two frames of reference, with their associated disciplines and methods, each of which is then brought separately to bear on the issues and dilemmas presented by organizational clients? Or is it more like Bion’s “reversible perspective” in which the same phenomena can be seen now this way, now that, as in the figure/ground illusions (?) Or again, is it rather a clumsy, provisional way of pointing to or naming something new, neither ‘psycho-analytic’ nor ‘systemic, but ‘psycho-analytic – and –systemic’; an emergent but not yet fully distributed third (Armstrong, 1995, p. 1).”

Jaques’ “conceptual splitting” between psychoanalytic and systemic approaches, Armstrong’s views on the unclear coupling of the two frames of reference, and the many questions raised while teaching these subjects, led me to try and explore further some aspects of the meeting space created – or could be created – by psychoanalysis and open systems theory.

I would like to begin by describing two experiences I had, that helped me formulate the ideas I will be presenting here.

In the summer of 1996 I attended the annual ISPSO conference in New York. In the member’s day which preceded the conference a discussion developed where members of the organization raised questions, such as: “what in fact are we doing here together at these annual meetings?”, and “what is actually the purpose of our organization?” After a few minutes of a rather tense discussion, one of the members - Gordon Lawrence- got up and said that one could say that this organization is “a container available for thinking”. This was a formulation of a primary task that I assumed meant that this organization – ISPSO - is a container in which we can think together about subjects related to the study of organizational processes from a psychoanalytic standpoint. It’s true, I thought to myself, this organization, which at this very moment is in a luxurious hall at the Manhattan Mariott, is in a sense a container - an almost concrete one - inside which we, the members of the organization, act, think and work, and the work we are doing now

is to clarify the nature of the organization and its dynamics. It seemed to me that Gordon Lawrence's conceptualization sounded reasonable to members and that it had to some extent dispelled the tension and opened many possibilities for further discussion. The container has been defined - now there is something that envelops us - so we can now move on and carry on with our work. The members then discussed the various dynamics of the organization: someone asked, for example, why so few members came to the conference, and how we could understand that. During the discussion on this topic, the president of the organization made a comment about his own and the executive board's mandates which weren't clear. I mused over the fact that once the container was defined, a topic connected with its management was raised. Containers have boundaries, I thought to myself. It appears obvious, yet I knew how slippery these boundaries might actually be and/or experienced to be. I thought also that in order for good and effective work to be done inside a "container", its boundaries – of task, role, authority, etc – must be defined and managed in a good enough way. I then said things in this spirit, and connected it to the President's lack of clarity regarding his own and the executive board's mandate.

The notion of a "container" (the organization as a whole or the actual meeting of a Member's Day) which is exemplified above, leads to my second experience, connected with my work as an organizational consultant in a human service organization, where I worked for several years. The newly appointed director of the organization invited the consultation. Already at the early stages of the organizational diagnosis it turned out that the organization was in a bad state: splits, coalitions, hostile relations and distrust prevailed. The board of the organization had not been convened for over a year due to the poor relations between its members. During the first months of my work with the board, I tried mainly to help it formulate its roles, to decide on who belongs to the board and who doesn't, to decide on the task, the frequency, the length and the structure of the board meetings, as well as the process of making decisions. I also suggested that they hold a review period at the end of each meeting. Later during that year, I helped the director and the board to assimilate these changes, and also worked with the board on other issues.

It was very clear that the poor interpersonal relationship among members of the board had a highly negative impact on everything taking place at all levels across the organization. Breaches of confidence, hostility and distrust were always present. I chose then not to devote a meeting to these fundamental issues, even though they came out in the open from time to time, and it was clear that nearly every discussion, no matter how task oriented it was, was suffused by these dynamics. Over a year passed before it was agreed with the director, at my initiative, that the board would discuss the topic of "trust at work." At that stage of the consultation my working arrangement with the board was such that I would spend several hours with it working on a number of chosen topics, after which I would leave the meeting and the board would continue with its daily work. The discussion held on the subject of trust at work was acrimonious and stormy, and it was hard to see how the members of the board could continue to work together, and how they would continue the meeting after I left. I found my role difficult, and as the person responsible for running this part of the meeting, I decided to cancel the discussion on another topic planned for the same meeting. There was a lot of pressure to continue and not to close this part of the meeting at the appointed time. The heated discussion was at its height when that time came. "We just can't stop now, when such harsh things are being said," one of the members said. During the discussion, I skipped the scheduled break, but it was clear to me that there were many things that hadn't been said, and that the problems in question would not be resolved during the discussion. Despite the pressure of the members, and a certain reluctance I felt within myself, I closed the discussion only a little after the scheduled time. Everyone understood that I was keeping more or less to the time boundaries as had been planned, despite the intense hostility in the air. I left with a very discomfited feeling. That evening the director called me to tell that the rest of the meeting devoted to routine issues had been productive and effective.

This description will serve as a basis for discussing some main issues presented in this paper. At this stage, I will only say that I then said to myself that it would had been impossible to hold such a discussion in the board a year or even six months earlier. I also believed that it was the fact that the board had been meeting regularly for more than a year and had also established relatively stable patterns of work that had helped create a framework - a "container" in the

language of this paper - that could contain the contents that came up during the presented meeting, as well as in previous meetings, without falling apart. While thinking about the "container" that was able to hold such heated discussion, I remembered how at the beginning of my work with this organization, in the consultancy contract I made with the director of the organization and the Director-General of the relevant governmental ministry, I defined the aim of the consultation – borrowing from Winnicott - as: assisting the organization to create a "holding organizational environment."

Let me turn now to the concepts of container and containment. In psychoanalytic theory, the term container is associated first and foremost with the development of the concept of projective identification. While Melanie Klein (1946), who coined the term projective identification, was referring to it as representing an intrapsychic phenomenon, many of her followers, the most well-known of whom is Bion, referred to it as an inter-personal phenomenon. Projective identification can be regarded as a phenomenon in which a person projects a part of himself into another object (not onto it, as occurs in projection) and brings about a change in the psychic reality of the receiver of the projection. One can speak in terms of the projective identification of "bad" parts that spoil the object, or of projective identification of "ideal" and "grandiose" parts which lead to the idealization of the object, but an idealization experienced by the receiving object as controlling and precarious (Nutkevitch, 1991). Since in projective identification, a part of the self is projected into an object, the object then can be regarded as a container that contains what has been projected into it. Projective identification in its inter-personal sense has become a cornerstone of theories developed by Bion in relation to infant development, the development of thought, the analytic situation, as well as in relation to processes in groups and in society in general. Bion (1962) developed various concepts related to the process of projective identification, both in relation to infant-mother relationship as well as to patient-therapist relationship. Thus, he would say that the infant projected a beta element into the mother. A beta element is a psychic element, which one constantly strives to get rid of through projective identification. The affective and mental condition of a mother capable of taking in what has been projected and remaining with it, Bion called reverie. In a state of reverie, the mother turns the

beta element into an alpha element with the help of an alpha function. An alpha element is a psychic element that has a name, that can be used for thinking, which enables the mother to act in ways characterized by an understanding of the anxious infant, rather than acting to rid herself of what has been projected into her.

This process of mother-infant relations is reconstructed in the therapeutic situation. We speak then in terms of the therapist as “a container”, the therapist who has “containment ability”, a meeting in which “the therapist could contain”, and another in which “he could not contain” what was projected into him, and had acted out in the counter transference. With the development of the intersubjective approach in psychoanalysis (Berman, 1997), one can no longer relate to the container as empty. The reactions of the therapist to his patient in many cases are not only the result of the patient’s projective identification, but rather a mixture of projected parts of the patient as well as denied and split off parts of the therapist. One can now ask on what depends the therapist’s ability to contain both projected parts of the patient and anxiety-laden parts of his own self? Are there preconditions that determine this ability? Can one create conditions that will serve the therapist in his difficult task, which requires the containment of the patient’s projective identifications? Unquestionably, the structure of the therapist’s personality is a key factor in his containment capability. But can we not argue that the clear boundaries that exist in the psychotherapeutic situation, in relation to time, method of work, payment arrangements, and the like, play a role in the therapist’s containment ability and in the creation of a containing therapeutic environment? The literature review and discussion of these questions is beyond the scope of this paper, yet the questions are relevant to organizational processes, on which I will focus from here on.

To preface the discussion on this aspect of organizational life, I will sum up schematically the phenomenon of containment as follows: “to contain” and “containment” are concepts that describe the capacity of any entity to keep within itself parts that arouse anxiety, pain and shame. Thus we can say that the infant as an entity is unable to contain parts that arouse anxiety in relation to himself and hence projects them via projective identification into another entity - the mother. The mother, in one situation, leaves this part inside her, despite the anxiety it arouses, digests it and turns it into an alpha element, and thus contains it; or in

another situation, is incapable of containing it, and projects it into the child or another person with whom she is interacting.

In parallel, I would say that an individual, a group, a system and an entire organization are all entities which may have inside them anxiety laden and unbearable parts, or into which anxiety-provoking parts can be projected; and like any object at the receiving end of projective identification, these entities can either keep and contain these unbearable parts or get rid of them by projecting them into a sub-entity inside them (a sub-group or sub-system) or into an external entity.

For example, in an organization in the private sector where I worked as a consultant, workers were in the habit of furtively whispering derogatory comments about various board members to other members of the board, or reporting things that "were said" about one of them by a certain board member. This situation naturally created an atmosphere of suspicion and hostility among the board members, as well as between the workers and the board and among the workers themselves. This relationship between workers and board can be understood, on the one hand, as a result of processes of projective identification of suspicious and aggressive parts into the board space, and on the other hand, as a result of a dynamic of suspicion and aggression between board members in which the workers have become involved. The members of the board accused each other of conspiring against one another, of disloyalty, and of responsibility for the poisonous atmosphere. If the board members had been capable of openly discussing these phenomena, talking about the dilemmas the situation raises, suggesting hypotheses regarding these processes, taking responsibility for their share in "being dragged into" these conversations with workers, or even initiating some of these phenomena, and taking decisions to prevent such situations, then one could say that the board is containing what has been projected into it and/or exists inside it. Or in other words, it could be said that such work by the board would have entailed transforming beta elements into alpha elements, a process that would have allowed for constructive actions to be taken . In this organization no such discussion took place. The board members continued to accuse each other and some of them tried, in various ways, to get back at the workers and/or their fellow members of the board. In this way, they significantly impaired the functioning of the entire organization: the board perpetuated the situation of non-containment.

In his article "Container and Contained" Bion (1977) developed another aspect of what needs to be contained in groups and society, and the role of the leading entity in this respect. He asserted that the individual in a group or society that is perceived as a "mystic" is felt to be threatening to the group or to society. The group might then ostracize or actually get rid of that individual. Bion claims that if that individual is not kept – that is contained - in the group, this might lead to the group's destruction. He gives the example of the non-containment of Jesus by the Jewish religious establishment, and the damage this caused, in his view, to the Jewish people. It is not only that the group must be capable of containing such an individual within it, the containment should prevent the possible destruction of the group. According to Bion, the group has the function of enabling the existence of – and even creating – the "mystic", who is not only potentially destructive, but is also potentially creative, and thus, able to advance the group. He speaks about the group's "establishment" whose function it is to contain the threatening individual. He thus assigns a decisive role in the containment process to the "establishment", to the entity with authority in the group and in the organization; to the entity that we might call, for example, the "board".

Stokes (1994) relates to this issue of containment and the board's role concerning it, in his article about institutional chaos. He deals there with the relationship between the distress of the individual in an organization and the organization's capability of containment. According to Stokes, the individual, in his affiliation with the organization, is psychologically supported by it, but this does not prevent the individual from also harboring feelings of hatred towards the organization, and fearing it, owing to the power he attributes to it. He asserts that the individual must be capable of attributing to the organization and the board or the management that heads it characteristics that arouse his hatred, hostility and envy. However, when the management is perceived as weak, the individual will direct such feelings to other parts of the organization, a situation that will lead to interpersonal and inter-group conflicts, as well as personal distress. In order to avoid the creation of such a situation, the board must be stable enough to provide a clear goal, and to serve as a "reliable container" (Stokes, 1994) that contains what is projected into it. What, then, is essential for the board to constitute a reliable container? Stokes (1994) enumerates two major factors: 1) ongoing work by the

board in clarifying the primary task of the organization; 2) work by the board in planning and defining roles in a manner consistent with the primary task. Obholzer (1994) widens the scope of the projective process and enumerates the necessary requirements for the organization to be able to contain these projections. According to him, society needs various institutions - he relates mainly to organizations in the public sector - as containers for the anxieties it projects. When these institutions do not acknowledge their function as containers and are not aware of the anxieties projected into them, they will create structures and will function in modes that constitute a defense against these anxieties. This situation will impair not only the work itself, but also the psychic and physical health of the workers and their families. In addition to these anxieties projected from the society, Obholzer also points out anxieties that arise from the very nature of the work, and anxieties that arise from the personal histories of the workers. He states that institutions must contain these anxieties, and enumerates a number of factors that will promote what he calls "the containing function of an organization": 1) There should be an ongoing discussion in relation to the organization's primary task; 2) The structure of authority should be clear, including who decides at the end of the discussion what the primary task is; 3) There should be open communication between the different parts of the organization. For this purpose, there should be a forum in which topics related to what is taking place in the organization, and between the organization and other systems can be discussed. 4) Teams should have regular meetings in which they speak about their feelings and their work-related difficulties; 5) Managers need special support. Obholzer doesn't explicitly assign a special role to the board of the organization. Yet, it could be assumed that the fulfillment of these requirements requires a board that can initiate and implement the above recommendations. As we have seen, Bion, Stokes and Obholzer - each from his own vantage point – attribute to an organization a containing function, and at least Bion and Stokes attach much importance to the function of the entity which has the power in the organization, be it the "establishment", the management or the board

I would now like to suggest to relate to a board on an organization from two perspectives: First, as a "container" of threatening and anxiety-arousing parts that stem from the inner dynamics of the board itself, as well as from projective

identifications emanating from both within and without the organization. From this perspective, a board that is capable of transforming the anxiety-arousing parts – "beta elements" – into "alpha elements" will diminish the damage and the personal and organizational distress that Stokes (1994) and Obholzer (1994) describe. Second, boards have naturally work related tasks to perform in order for the organization to function and exist. As such, I view the board as a "container" in which work is performed (see Lawrence's, remark in my first example, p.3). A board, important as it is, is in fact, only one example of a work group in an organization. I view every group of persons - small or large - every system or organizational entity that have a task as a container in which work is performed. Now I can expand the meaning of a "reliable container", or borrowing from Winnicott (1960), speak of a "good enough container." A "good enough container" is any organizational entity that can: 1) Like a mother or therapist, contain the anxiety-provoking parts that originate both within that "container", and/or from projective identifications originating in the container's environment (close and remote). 2) Enable and promote efficient and creative work connected with the "container's" work related tasks. A "good enough container" is not only "a shock absorber" (of projective identifications); it also enables personal and team excellence. A "good enough container" enables people to realize their personal potential, makes possible the existence of the "mystic", Bion (1977); enables the expression of the mystic that is in each one of us, and harnesses them to the tasks of the container.

All of us have experienced, I assume, group processes that Bion (1961) described as anxieties and defenses associated with his theory of group's "basic assumptions"; processes that might potentially impair the group's ability to work on its formal task. Group processes are overtly or covertly impacted by what takes place in other parts of the organization, as well as by systems outside the organization and society at large. These intra-group as well as inter-group and societal processes, may adversely affect the functioning of every working group. A working group or a system that constitutes a "good enough container" allows for good work despite these processes, which are an inseparable part of the life of groups and organizations. I would like now to remind us of my first example regarding the ISPSO symposium. I thought back then in New York that the

functioning of ISPSO as a container[1] depends to a larger extent on the way its boundaries are managed, I would like to suggest that boundary management is a central factor in the ability of any organizational entity, be it the secretarial staff or top management, to function as a "good enough container". To develop further these ideas I will turn to "open systems theory" (Miller and Rice, 1967), a theory that regards "management of boundaries" as a central concept.

The open systems theory of organizations, as developed by Miller and Rice (1967) asserts that the management of the system's boundaries is essential for its efficient functioning. According to this approach, a manager at whatever level of management is not situated above the system he manages but at its boundary; and his role is to manage this boundary. In other words, his role is to manage boundaries of task, time, territory, decision-making process, etc. In the conceptualization of the present article, I could say that the manager manages the boundaries of the "container" in order to create a "good enough container". Figuratively, one could think of the manager (at any level and in any framework) as one whose role is as if "to hold" the "container" in his hands and see to the existence and intactness of the "container's" envelope: an envelope of task, of time, of territory, of membership, etc.

Thus, one could say that every "container" in order to function as a "good enough container", i.e. containing threatening and anxiety-provoking parts and providing a space where work is performed; needs "a function" that will maintain and manage its boundaries. This function can have many names: director-general, team head, manager, instructor, chairman, president, commander, and the like. These are all roles or organizational functions that carry responsibility and have authority. As figures of authority the persons in these roles arouse anxiety, aggression and envy and the group's projective identifications are directed at them (Bion, 1961). They themselves are containers too, one person containers; and like the mother and the therapist, should be capable of containment. Most of us would recognize the pressures under which every manager operates in his attempts to keep and hold the "container's" boundaries. To perform this task, the manager must possess leadership and courage. We all, in our various jobs, are familiar with statements like: "Let's leave this topic now and move on to another one," "We need to shorten the meeting," "Uzzi is on vacation, so let's cancel the scheduled

board meeting." These statements can be viewed as concrete examples related to the manager's role of managing the "container's" boundaries, which means constantly having to take decisions relating to various aspects of these boundaries. However, statements like the above stated during a board meeting, may at times arise out of rivalry, divisiveness, and projection that threaten the manager's functioning and the intactness and functioning of the board as a "good enough container". One obvious conclusion is that the board as a "container", or, for that matter, any other organizational entity, has also to be contained. Organizational consultants always strive to work with those who are at the top of the system's hierarchy, as these persons have much influence over the whole system. Yet, I consider working with those at "the top" as highly relevant to the notion of container: these persons are not only at the top of an organization but also at the top of the board that is supposed to manage the organization. Their ability to manage the boundaries of the "container"/board, and thus to contain the "container"/board in order to maintain a "good enough container", is crucial for the organization's functioning and the well being of its members. The manager's personality make-up is a significant factor in his containment ability, but it is not the sole important factor. I would like to suggest that while the manager, as part of his role, has to manage the boundaries of the "container", these boundaries also sustain him. In difficult and stormy moments, his reliance on or adherence to boundaries of task, of time, of territory, etc., is what, in the final analysis, will maintain the intactness and vitality of the "container".

To partially sum up, I can state that the clarification of the boundaries of task, time, role, authority, decision-making processes, etc. is important, as many have claimed, for the effective functioning of the organization. I maintain that the clarification, formulation, awareness and management of these boundaries constitutes a kind of "safety net" for the existence, intactness and effectiveness of a "container" in its diverse meanings. This is a man-made net, and as such needs to be woven by people; but the very fact of its existence helps people in a managerial role maintain their containment ability, and hence the intactness of the system/team/board/"container" they manage. In this context, there is much relevance to the saying: "More than the Jewish people observes the Sabbath, the Sabbath preserves the Jewish people."

Let me go back to my second example in the organization where I worked as a consultant. At the board meeting called to discuss the subject of trust at work, the existence of the task boundaries, manifested in the agenda, the planned time boundaries, and the boundaries of my authority as the person running the meeting, all helped me to steer the discussion through the stormy waters. In my opinion, the fact that I kept or managed the boundaries of the time frame, despite the difficulties, constituted an act of containment that enabled the board to continue functioning, even effectively so, after my departure. The time boundaries thus maintained or "preserved" me, while I maintained them, and constituted a kind of safety net that helped me contain the "container"/board that was "boiling over."

The dialectic that exists between "the preservation of the Jewish people" and "the observing of the Sabbath" represents the dialectic that exists between the intactness of the "container" and its boundaries; between measurable boundaries (of task, time, territory, decision-making processes, etc.) and evasive anxieties and defenses that often threaten these boundaries and thus the "container". It touches therefor on the dialectic between the open systems theory and its applications in relation to primary task, structure, roles and design of work, and the psychoanalytic theory and its understandings regarding the often invisible and slippery matrix of anxieties and projective identifications that do not submit to the authority of boundaries, and which we and the "containers" to which we belong have to work through and contain.

The "container" and the "means of containing it" thus constitute a meeting place between psychoanalytic theory and open systems theory. Hence, an organizational consultant working with the aim of assisting organizations and their managers in creating and managing "good enough containers" is in fact operating from a psychoanalytic perspective as well as from an open systems perspective. Furthermore, helping the board of an organization in the process of formulating its tasks and roles, in establishing meeting procedures regarding time, frequency, agenda setting, decision-making processes etc., may seem to be focusing on "technical" and "practical" issues. However, I claim that in dealing with these issues that are related to open systems theory, we are to a no lesser degree guided by and applying psychoanalytic understandings. The emphasis a consultant places

on the structure and design of organizational entities constitutes, in my view, a pivotal factor in organizational consultancy guided by a psychoanalytic approach. This emphasis on structure and design in no way disregards the need for understanding, relating to and working on unconscious processes on the level of the individual, the group, the organization and the processes associated with society at large. Anxieties, defense mechanisms and defensive structures (Menzies, 1960) are extremely important conceptual prisms through which we gain understandings regarding what is happening, to decide upon a consultative intervention and to navigate through the complex and difficult terrain of the consultative process.

Concluding Thoughts

The stormier the "container", the more serious the organization's pathology is, the worse the relations within the organization's board, the harder the task of containment for the personality make-up of the manager, the more important it is to build and maintain the "safety net," which becomes critical for the containment of the "container". The more there are "good enough containers" in the organization, at all levels – board, management, department, team, working group - the more efficiently it will function and the more efficient, creative and satisfied with their jobs the members of the organization will be. Thus, establishing "good enough containers" in an organization can be viewed as a "consultancy vision" that contains within it not only the idea of helping the organization to achieve its tasks effectively, but also includes values of creativity and satisfaction, which make the individual and his well being a key value in the work of the consultant. This vision, which embraces a professional conceptual framework, as well as professional values, points out for the consultant the direction of an important intervention strategy: a strategy that helps establish, maintain and manage organizational entities or "containers", on all levels, as "good enough containers".

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